PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #17 · SOCIAL ISOLATION · GIVEN UP ON PEOPLE

“I’ve given up on letting people in.”

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Have you stopped trying to let people get close? Does it feel as though your shield is up for good and you no longer expect anything to change? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward opening the door, even a crack, and to find the hope that comes from knowing God’s word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

Long seasons of disappointment, rejection, or loss can lead a person to quit trying. The shield that was once raised for protection becomes permanent, and the person may even feel relief at no longer hoping. Emotions can seem “switched off” because feeling them hurt too much. This is a way of coping, and it is often a sign of past pain, not of coldness.

How the belief can keep itself going

Giving up does protect from fresh disappointment, so the belief feels sensible. But a closed door cannot be tested, and so nothing new ever happens to change it. Hope deferred is painful, and the person may not notice how much has been lost: comfort, laughter, help, and being known.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest that “hope deferred makes the heart sick,” but it also says, “He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds,” and “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish.” God is gentle with those who have given up. “Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another.” Giving up on people is understandable. Giving up on God’s ability to heal and restore is not necessary.

> *“A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice.” (Isaiah 42:3)*

Also see

> “Hope deferred makes the heart sick, but desire fulfilled is a tree of life.” (Proverbs 13:12)

> “He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.” (Psalm 147:3)

> “Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor.” (Ecclesiastes 4:9)

> “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest.” (Matthew 11:28)

Common self-statements

- I am done trying.
- It never works out.
- I have shut that part of me off.
- I would rather not hope.
- Nothing will change.
- I do not feel anything anymore.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing it is either perfect closeness or none at all.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that every attempt will end in disappointment.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling numb and concluding that I no longer need anyone.
- Overgeneralizing: Letting a few painful relationships stand for everyone.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking small moments of warmth.
- Mislabeling: Calling protection "giving up."

Challenging questions

- What happened that led me to stop trying?
- Was there a time I let someone in and it went well, even a little?
- What have I lost since I closed the door?
- Is it possible to open it only a crack and only for someone safe?
- What does it mean that God does not break a bruised reed?
- What would my life look like with one safe friend?
- If a friend told me they had given up on people, what would I want them to know?

Truth summary

My shield was built for good reasons, and I do not have to take it down all at once. God is gentle with bruised hearts. I can open the door a little, for someone safe, and let Him heal and restore what I thought was gone.

A short prayer

Lord, I have put up my shield and I am tired of hoping. You do not break bruised reeds. Heal what has been wounded, and help me open the door a little, to someone safe. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hopeless
- Loneliness
- Friendship
- Depression, Symptoms of

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Suffering

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Just Be Held
Casting Crowns

God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm
Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham

Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Living Hope
Phil Wickham

Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Blessed Assurance
Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither

This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this appear in Beck and Freeman's discussion of what clinicians call schizoid personality disorder (Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders, 1990, pp. 359–363), where a person has "given up" on others and emotions are switched off. A permanent shield is often protective and rooted in earlier injury. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Similar presentations can arise from depression, trauma, social anxiety, autism spectrum differences, or temperament, so careful assessment matters. Pace any experiments to the person; someone with severe depression or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "Who could I open the door to, just a crack, today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I've given up on letting people in."

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Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "I've given up on letting people in." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you catch yourself thinking, "I've given up on letting people in."

- ☐ What happened that led me to stop trying?
- ☐ Was there a time I let someone in and it went well, even a little?
- ☐ What have I lost since I closed the door?
- ☐ Is it possible to open it only a crack and only for someone safe?
- ☐ What does it mean that God does not break a bruised reed?
- ☐ What would my life look like with one safe friend?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ God is gentle with bruised hearts.
- ☐ I can open the door a little at a time.
- ☐ Hope can be rebuilt slowly.
- ☐ One safe person is a beginning.
- ☐ Giving up was protection, and I can choose differently.
- ☐ God heals the brokenhearted.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Isaiah 42:3
  "A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice."
- ☐ Proverbs 13:12
  "Hope deferred makes the heart sick, but desire fulfilled is a tree of life."
- ☐ Psalm 147:3
  "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds."
- ☐ Ecclesiastes 4:9
  "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor."

☐ Matthew 11:28
“Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest.”

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

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5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Hopeless. Listen to Overcoming Depression. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ List three times someone showed you kindness, and note how it felt.
- ☐ Say hello to one person you would usually avoid, and stay for a minute.
- ☐ Send a short message to someone you have not spoken to in a while.
- ☐ Accept a small invitation, and stay a short, set time.
- ☐ Spend a few minutes noticing something good about one person.
- ☐ Write a prayer asking God to bring one safe person into your life.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about being held, healed, and given hope.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~I've given up on letting people in.~~

NEW TRUTH:
God is gentle with my bruised heart. I can open the door a little, to someone safe, and let Him restore what I thought was lost.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Isaiah 42:3

A short prayer

Lord, thank You for being gentle with me. Give me courage to open the door a little, and bring safe people into my life. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.